



Defensible Space and Home Hardening Checklist

Homes are usually lost to flying embers and to fuel touching the house, not to a wall of flame. Two things give a house its best chance: clearing the space around it, and closing the gaps embers get through. Work from the walls outward.

START WITH THE FIRST FIVE FEET

If you only get one afternoon, spend it in the five feet closest to your walls and under your deck. That strip decides more than the rest of the property combined, and it is the cheapest part to fix.

ZONE 0: THE FIRST FIVE FEET

- ☐ Gravel, pavers, or concrete instead of bark or wood-chip mulch
- ☐ Clear dead weeds, grass, leaves, and debris, including roofs, gutters, and corners
- ☐ Keep branches at least 10 feet from chimneys and stovepipes
- ☐ Move planters, furniture, and anything combustible off decks in this zone
- ☐ Move firewood and lumber piles out to Zone 2
- ☐ Replace wood fencing and gates where they touch the house
- ☐ Relocate garbage and recycling bins out of this zone
- ☐ Move boats, RVs, and vehicles out of this zone

ZONE 1: FIVE TO THIRTY FEET

- ☐ Clear dead plants, grass, and weeds
- ☐ Remove dead leaves and needles from the yard, the roof, and the gutters
- ☐ Trim overhanging branches, keeping 10 feet from the chimney
- ☐ Keep a 10-foot gap between tree canopies
- ☐ Prune flammable shrubs back from windows
- ☐ Clear vegetation and stored items out from under decks, balconies, and stairs
- ☐ Keep space between trees, shrubs, patio furniture, and wood piles
- ☐ Give outbuildings and propane tanks 10 feet of clearance to bare soil, and no flammable plants for another 10 feet beyond that

ZONE 2: THIRTY TO ONE HUNDRED FEET

- ☐ Cut annual grass to a maximum height of four inches

- ☐ Space out shrubs and trees, with more space on steeper slopes
- ☐ Keep vertical gaps between grass, shrubs, and low branches so fire cannot climb
- ☐ Remove fallen leaves, needles, and small branches; a layer up to three inches deep can stay
- ☐ Keep wood piles clear 10 feet all around, down to bare soil

HOME HARDENING: CLOSE THE GAPS EMBERS USE

- ☐ **Roof:** keep it clear of leaves and needles. Wood shake is the highest risk; composite, metal, tile, and asphalt resist fire.
- ☐ **Chimney and stovepipe:** noncombustible metal screen, openings between 3/8 and 1/2 inch
- ☐ **Vents:** 1/16 to 1/8 inch noncombustible metal mesh. Plastic and fiberglass screen melt.
- ☐ **Windows:** dual-pane with at least one tempered layer resists breaking in heat
- ☐ **Gutters:** keep clear, and consider noncombustible guards and a metal drip edge
- ☐ **Decks:** ignition-resistant materials, and nothing flammable stored underneath
- ☐ **Eaves and soffits:** box them in with noncombustible or ignition-resistant material
- ☐ **Walls:** stucco, fiber cement, or other noncombustible siding, foundation to roofline
- ☐ **Garage:** weather-strip the door against embers, keep an extinguisher handy, and know how to open the door with the power out
- ☐ **Fences:** noncombustible material where the fence meets the house
- ☐ **Address:** house number visible from the road and reflective at night, so an engine finds you fast
- ☐ **Driveway:** 10 feet of vegetation clearance each side and trimmed overhead branches, so a fire engine can get in

THREE NOTES FOR UP HERE

Hire out the big tree work. Limbing tall trees and removing hazard trees near a house is professional work. Our tree-service guide at bouldercreeklocal.com lists local options and what to check before hiring.

Watch the weather before you start. Do this work outside red-flag and high-fire-danger days, and keep spark-throwing equipment (mowers, grinders, chainsaws) off on hot, dry, windy afternoons.

Free chipping exists. The Resource Conservation District chips defensible-space cuttings at no cost, usually registering in April for chipping in early May, for material from within 100 feet of a structure or 15 feet of a private road.

WHAT IS REQUIRED, AND WHO TO ASK

Defensible space in Zones 1 and 2 is required by state law in this area, and local requirements can be stricter. Zone 0 is current best practice and the rules for it are still being finalized statewide. Confirm what applies to your property with **CAL FIRE** and the **Boulder Creek Fire Protection District**, (831) 338-7222. For any fire or emergency, call 911.

Condensed from CAL FIRE's Ready for Wildfire defensible space and home hardening guidance (readyforwildfire.org). Chipping-program details from the Resource Conservation District of Santa Cruz County. Checked July 2026; requirements change, so confirm before you rely on any measurement here.